



More mobile apps

Nokia announces the launch of virtual OVI mobile app store as competition to the i-Tunes store.



Save 9-77-33-00000 on your phonebook for quick and easy access to Google SMS.

this service enables users to search for local businesses or movie show-times by calling a toll free number. The results are then sent to you via SMS. We decided to give it a shot. We called up 1-800-41-999-999 and the automated IVR menu asked us to state business and location. Surprisingly it did recognise in the second try and sent us a single listing of Healthy Meal Tiffin Service in Ghatkopar (no where near our office which is in Vashi). Still not bad, though we would've liked a few more results. Google claims to transfer the call to an operator after two failed attempts at recognition. We decided to put this to test too, so for business name we said "Ding Dong". Obviously after two attempts at recognising 'ding dong' as a business name, the operator came on. When asked him for listings of Tiffin Services and he seemed not at all inclined to narrow down the location. When prompted from our end he was willing to send area specific listings. Otherwise he was going send the first three listings for the keywords 'Tiffin Service'. How typically Google! (sponsored results anyone?) Also the three SMSs that we received were pretty garbled. Incidentally the same service is available via SMS. Simply send your search query to 9-77-33-00000 and wait for the listings to be sent to you almost instantaneously.

Google Latitude

Google seems to be giving a major push to their mobile invasion lately. Its comforting enough to know that Google already knows more about us than we do ourselves. Be it our searches, mails, likes dislikes, and here's yet another case Google trying to pervade another aspect of our lives. This time it seems Google wants to pin point our location! Okay perhaps this is a very paranoid way of looking at the recent launch of Google's Latitude. The new service from Google is supposed to be a feature added to Google Maps for mobile that allows you pinpoint your friends location on a map. Your first reaction might be "oh that's nice, who can I stalk or spy on?" But remember, even your location can be triangulated! Now are you thinking "that's kinda creepy"? Well Google's take on the service goes something like this - "Once you've opted in to Latitude, you can see the approximate location of your friends and loved ones who have decided to share their location with you. So now you can do things like see if your spouse is stuck in traffic on the way home from work, notice that a buddy is in town for the weekend, or take comfort in knowing that a loved one's flight landed safely, despite bad weather."

Jokes and paranoia aside, it may indeed have some uses. You may really want to share your location with people you're really close to. You could use it to show off too. Yes, apart from automatically detecting your location you can manually set your location with the desktop version of the service via the Latitude iGoogle gadget. So you can even set your location to Paris if you wish. Perhaps concerned parents could use it to keep tabs on delinquent teenagers? Also to dispel a bit of paranoia, all this 'sharing' business is entirely as per your choice. You can choose who to share your location with and vice-versa. You can also decide what level of specific location you want to go into ie. your best available location or your city-level location. Latitude currently is available on Blackberry, Windows Mobile, and most Symbian S60 and Java-enabled (J2ME) mobile phones and the app can be downloaded from www.google.com/latitude. ■

